keyboard on a PDA, one could enter the data using a standard keyboard on a computer and sync it to the device.

A novel device that gained popularity in the 90s but faded away soon after was the Digital Diary. At its core, a digital diary was a digital assistant to your daily life, allowing you to store a variety of information and retrieve it later. They were capable of storing calendar entries, text and voice memos, todo lists and included productivity software such as an address book, calculator, world time and alarm. Since all of these functions began to get integrated with phones and PDAs in the coming years, people lost interest in these standalone devices that lacked connectivity features.

The first tablet computers

Though the tablet market has received enormous attention and hype in the recent years, the concept of a tablet dates back to more than 20 years, when the first handheld slate-like devices were introduced. Interestingly, it was neither Microsoft nor Apple who spearheaded the innovation in this segment. As with most technology, there was a significant time lag between the conceptualisation and realisation of the product. The earliest concept of a tablet computer goes way back to 1960s, where Alan Kay envisioned a device called the 'DynaBook' that would function as a 'personal computer for all ages'. The device would use an LCD technology (revolutionary for the time) and a physical keyboard at the bottom. The concept had several features that would come to be implemented only decades later, such as the ability to connect to wireless networks, playback audio files and voice memos. It was intended to be a learning aid for children, and while it was never realised in practice, the idea served as a starting point for the future of handheld computing. Some of the notable ancestors to today's tablets are listed below:

1. The GRiDPad – GriD Systems

The first true tablet device was the GRiDpad, developed by GRiD Systems. The device boasted very impressive hardware specs for its time, including a 20MHz processor, 2MB of RAM, up to 120MB of storage, a 10" backlit VGA display and 3 hours of battery backup. Although the GRiDpad ran MS-DOS, it had some customizations built atop it to take advantage of the stylus input system. Jeff Hawkins even created a language called GRiDTask to quickly create and install simple applications for the device. He would later go on to leave the company and start his own company, Palm, which was responsible for a string of highly successful mobile devices.